

One Image, Many Readings Student Handout

TOK Cognitive Science Activity Bank • The Arts • 30-40 min

Category	The Arts	Time	30-40 min
Difficulty	Medium	ID	one-image-many-readings

Big idea: Evidence in interpretation is plural.

Student-Facing Prompt

Inspect One Image, Many Readings Stimulus A. Record one first claim, the evidence you used, your confidence, and what would make you revise.

Concrete Stimulus Packet

One Image, Many Readings Stimulus A	Student-facing stimulus 1: One ambiguous image interpreted through personal, cultural, political, and formal lenses. Describe what you see or hear first, then add title/context and revise the interpretation.	Students inspect this exact card first and commit to a claim before hearing anyone else.
One Image, Many Readings Stimulus B	Student-facing stimulus 2: A gallery walk where each group leaves a different reading. Describe what you see or hear first, then add title/context and revise the interpretation.	Use this for comparison, a second round, or a partner challenge.
One Image, Many Readings Reveal / Twist	Student-facing stimulus 3: A claim-evidence-context triangle for art interpretation. Describe what you see or hear first, then add title/context and revise the interpretation.	Teacher reveal: connect the changed response to the big idea — Evidence in interpretation is plural.

Actual Lesson Questions

#	Question for students
1	After inspecting One Image, Many Readings Stimulus A, what is your first knowledge claim?
2	Which exact detail from One Image, Many Readings Stimulus A did you use as evidence?
3	What did you infer beyond the evidence?
4	How confident are you: 50%, 60%, 70%, 80%, 90%, or 100%?
5	What missing information would most improve the knowledge claim?
6	Is ambiguity a weakness or strength in the arts?

Ready-to-Use Examples

- One ambiguous image interpreted through personal, cultural, political, and formal lenses.
- A gallery walk where each group leaves a different reading.
- A claim-evidence-context triangle for art interpretation.

Student Task

Use the stimulus cards to complete the observation/inference/evidence/confidence grid, then answer one TOK knowledge question connected to The Arts.

Activity Steps

1. Assign lenses: emotional, political, historical, technical, feminist, religious, personal, formal composition.
2. Groups produce a reading using at least three pieces of evidence from the work.
3. Groups compare compatible and incompatible interpretations.
4. Create class criteria for a strong interpretation.

Observation and Evidence Record

Use this grid to keep observation, inference, evidence, and confidence separate.

What I noticed	What I inferred	Evidence	Confidence

TOK Debrief

- Knowledge question: Is ambiguity a weakness or strength in the arts?
- What counts as evidence in artistic interpretation?
- Can art reveal truths that cannot be stated directly?

Knowledge Questions

- Is ambiguity a weakness or strength in the arts?
- What counts as evidence in artistic interpretation?
- Can art reveal truths that cannot be stated directly?

Transfer Example

For example, run this activity with one ambiguous image interpreted through personal, cultural, political, and formal lenses. Have students commit to an initial claim, then reveal the change, hidden rule, alternative context, or comparison that makes the knowledge problem visible.

Exit Ticket

- One thing I first treated as evidence was...
- My confidence changed because...
- A better knowledge question I can now ask is...